

Effort vs. Impact: D.C.'s Housing Ecosystem

Central Idea

Housing information exists — what's missing is someone to help residents find the piece that fits their situation.

Problem Statement

D.C. has valuable resources, but the pathways connecting residents to them are fragmented and difficult to navigate, and too often depend on whether someone happens to have the right connection or knows how to search for it.

Observation 1 — Websites create confusion, and the most valuable information often comes from showing up in person

Websites overwhelm more than they inform, and it's not always clear where to start. The information that actually helped me came from engaging with organizations directly. Free DC and Empower DC gave me legal knowledge I didn't know I needed — tenant rights, how to organize a tenant association. But Free DC offered more than that: they organize by ward, so I joined a Ward 5 meeting with neighbors in my own community, and they also run non-policy groups — gardening, knitting — just neighbors connecting. None of that shows up on a website. Getting oriented took some effort, since Free DC has many branches and moves you onto Signal to stay connected, but it got easier once I was through orientation. I saw a similar pattern with government technology: at a government building, the ID sign-in process called numbers for people who weren't even in the room, while people already waiting, who'd completed ID capture, were skipped. Both experiences raise the same question — how much friction and personal information should be required just to access help, and do people really understand what they're consenting to?

Observation 2 — The system asks for more commitment than residents are ready to give, and sometimes preys on people who don't know better

Some organizations meant to help residents navigate housing require a level of commitment upfront that doesn't match what residents actually want. Realtor agreements can lock someone into a long-term, exclusive relationship just to see a single house. Application fees add another barrier before someone even knows if a resource is the right fit. At the more extreme end, this same gap gets exploited outright — contractors scamming homeowners, and buyers pressuring elderly residents to sell their homes. The pattern is the same throughout: people are asked to commit, pay, or sign before they've had a real chance to understand what they're agreeing to or whether it's actually in their interest.

Dataset & Sources

- **Office of the Tenant Advocate (OTA)** — D.C. government agency offering free legal representation for landlord-tenant disputes, tenant association formation guidance, and a

published Tenant Bill of Rights. Publishes real data: eviction lists, monthly eviction data, rental application fee caps (\$54 for 2026).

- **DHCD Housing Production Trust Fund (HPTF)** — the District's main funding tool for producing and preserving affordable housing, financed through deed/transfer tax revenue plus a mayoral commitment of at least \$100M/year. Since 2015 it's helped create or preserve 9,000+ affordable units. Also supports tenant groups pursuing TOPA (buying their building).
- **National Housing Trust Fund (NHTF)** — a federal affordable-housing program (established 2008) administered locally by DHCD, targeted at extremely low-income households, including homeless individuals/families and people with special needs.
- **Office of Advisory Neighborhood Commissions (ANC)** — oversees D.C.'s elected, ward/neighborhood-level commissions, the most local layer of government where residents can raise housing and development issues directly.
- **Empower DC** — housing justice organizing group active since 2003, focused on preventing displacement of low-income residents, running Know Your Rights sessions and direct-assistance programs.
- **Free DC** — ward-based civic organizing network. Beyond policy work, it connects residents to each other through ward meetings and community groups — something only discoverable by joining, not from their website.

None of these are hard to find once you know to look for them — the gap is that a resident has to already know they need a funding program, a legal aid office, or a civic group before they'd ever land on one. That gap is even wider for residents new to the District — someone who relocated for a job, for example, has no existing network pointing them toward any of these, so they're navigating with even less context than a longtime resident.

Previous Solutions Tried

D.C. has real solutions already in motion — they just haven't closed the gap.

- **Legal aid and tenant advocacy (OTA, Empower DC):** free legal representation, tenant association guidance, know-your-rights education. Works well once found, but depends on already knowing legal help exists — usually only discovered after a crisis forces the search.
- **Funding programs (HPTF, NHTF):** put real money into building and preserving affordable housing — a supply-side solution. A resident with a fair housing unit still has no clear path to find out it exists or how to apply.
- **Civic access points (ANC, Free DC's ward-level organizing):** give residents a direct line to local government and each other. But awareness of these groups is itself a barrier — most residents don't know their ANC commissioner exists, and Free DC only reveals its full range of support once someone has already joined.

Each of these solves part of the problem — legal protection, funding, or civic access — but none solve the part where a resident has to already know which one they need. And even for a resident who does know what they're looking for, actually finding and using the right resource is still

overwhelming — different intake processes, different eligibility rules, different offices, different paperwork. Knowing the destination doesn't mean the path there is clear. That's the case for a navigator: someone (or something) whose job is to close that last gap, not just point at a list of options.

Hypothesis

A trusted housing navigator — connecting residents to education, programs, professionals, and organizations based on their specific situation — would close the gap that legal aid, funding programs, and civic access points can't close on their own. Not another directory, and not more information: a way to translate a resident's specific circumstance into the specific next step that fits them, the same way a person who already knows the system could.

The Paradox

D.C.'s housing resources are valuable because they're built to address real, specific needs — legal aid for tenants, funding for affordable units, ward-level access to government. But that same specificity is what makes them hard to find: each one only helps if you already know it exists and know it's the one that fits your situation. Make the system simpler by consolidating everything into one general resource, and it stops being specific enough to actually help anyone's particular case. Leave it as is, and only the people who already know how to navigate systems benefit — everyone else stays locked out, even once they've found the right door, because getting through it is still overwhelming on your own.